

Writing a Report



What is a Report?

A report is a practical document that describes, details or analyses a situation so that the reader can make decisions or take specific action.

Types of report

Product report

Business report

Lab report

Technical report

Case study report

Research report (inc. dissertations)

and more...

Reports vs Essays: A comparison

Similarities include:

- Requirement for research, planning and clear structure
- Critical analysis of evidence used to support points
- Accurate referencing of all sources
- Succinct, formal, objective, academic language
- Editing and proof-reading prior to submission

Reports vs Essays

Differences – a report is:

- **More formally structured**
(like a dissertation, it may have contents page, numbered sections, headings and sub-headings)
- **Focused on reader's needs**
(targeted towards a specific purpose)
- **Informative and fact based**
(as opposed to exploring arguments and ideas)
- **Includes recommendation for action**
- **May use tables, graphs, bullet points**

Purposes of Reports

Do not start work on a report until you clarify its purpose, which may be one or more of the following:

Informative

To define or establish a current situation

Explanatory

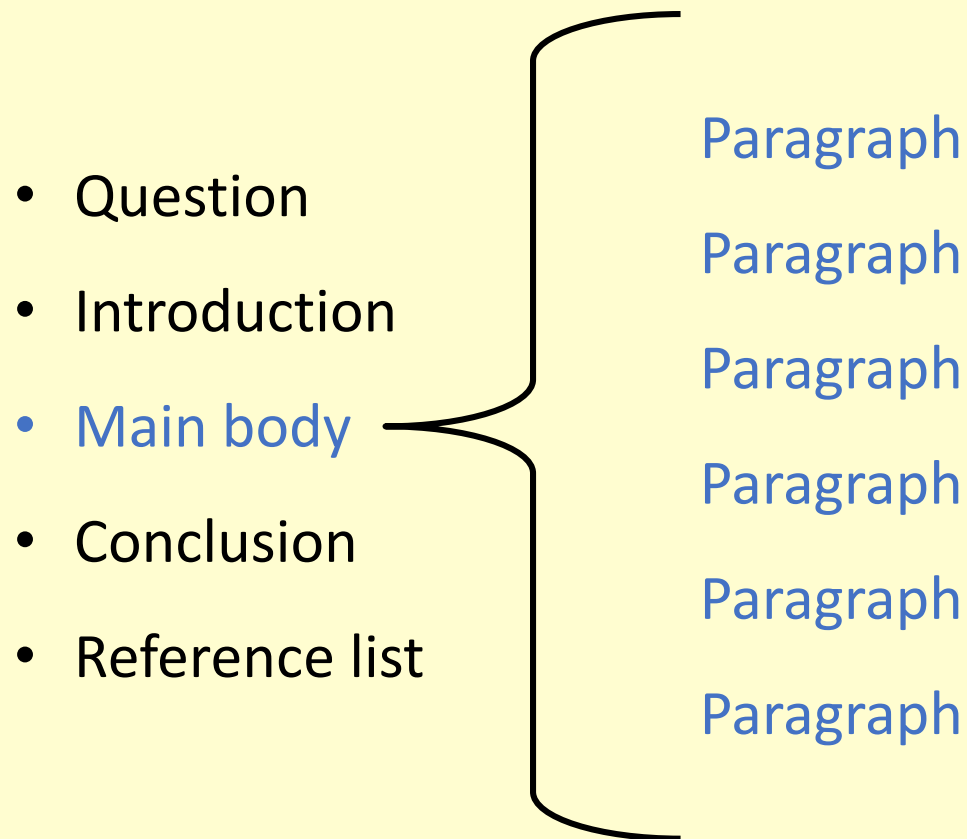
To explore and explain a situation and suggest *possible* actions

Persuasive

To investigate a problem and suggest a *specific* course of action

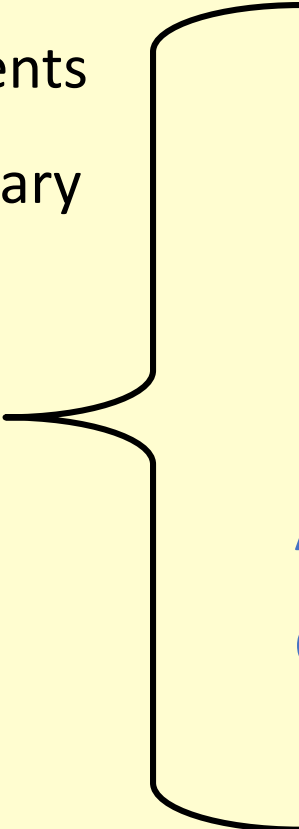
Structure (**Essay**)

This is the structure of a standard essay:



Structure (**Report**)

A report may contain many or all of the following:

- Title
 - Acknowledgements
 - Executive summary
 - Contents page
 - Main body
 - Bibliography
 - Appendices
- 
- Introduction
 - Background information
 - Methodology
 - Findings
 - Analysis
 - Conclusions
 - Recommendations

Overall structure: process of writing an effective Report

- Title (accurately reflecting the content of the report)
- Acknowledgements (*if* there are people or organisations you need to acknowledge as having contributed to the creation of the report)
- Executive summary (Also known as an 'abstract' - a brief, 200-300 word, standalone summary of the report, including background, key aims, methods, findings and conclusions)
- Contents page
- Main body (see next slide)
- Bibliography (for substantial reports at Masters and Phd level, a bibliography may reference sources *influential* to the work, in addition to work *cited* within it)
- Appendices (useful but supplementary information)

Clear *main body* structure

- Introduction (context, focus, aims, objectives of the report)
- Background information (anything the reader may need to know at the start in order to understand the content of the report)
(In a dissertation a Literature Review may go here)
- Methodology (how you found things out)
- Findings (what you found out)
- Analysis (understanding the findings, discussing what they mean)
- Conclusions (key things those findings indicate, clarify or confirm)
- Recommendations (Courses of action suggested by those findings)

Key characteristics

A report should:

- Perform a function, clarified at the outset
- Provide information in a logical, well sign-posted order
- Present ideas and information (whether written or visual) as clearly as possible
- Use critically analysed evidence to support conclusions
- Offer clear recommendations as requested
- Be accurately referenced and error-free on submission

INTRODUCTION



- **BUSINESS REPORT DEFINITION :-**
Business report is an **impartial, objective, planned presentation** of facts to one or more persons, for specific significant business purpose.
- The report facts could relate to events, conditions, qualities and progress results, products problem and suggested ideas.

Steps to be considered while writing business report-

- Determine the scope (purpose) of the report.
- Consider the target audience (readers).
- **Gather, organize, and analyse** the supporting information.
- Determine the solution, finding and or recommendation.
- Determining the report format.



Report presentation and layout:

➤ **FRONT MATTER**

- Title page
- Letter of transmittal
- Table of contents & lists of illustration
- Executive summary

➤ **REPORT BODY**

- Introduction and background information
- Report finding and discussion
- Conclusion and recommendation

➤ **END MATTER**

- Reference.
- Appendix.

Types of business report:

- 1) Routine report
- 2) Special report :



Short report ← → Long report

- Short report: (it can be personal, informal and relaxed)
- Long report – (it is formal, impersonal and restrained in tone)

❑ Long business report contains:-

- i) A covering letter or memorandum.
- ii) Title page.
- iii) Executive summary.
- iv) Table of contents.
- v) Introduction.
- vi) Conclusion/recommendation.
- vii) Findings and discussion.
- viii) Reference.
- ix) Appendices.

Report presentation and layout:

➤ **FRONT MATTER**

- Title page
- Letter of transmittal
- Table of contents & lists of illustration
- Executive summary

➤ **REPORT BODY**

- Introduction and background information
- Report finding and discussion
- Conclusion and recommendation

➤ **END MATTER**

- Reference.
- Appendix.

Report layout:

September 20, 2016

The sales Director

Xyz company

Assam

Subject: Report on decline of business.

Dear sir,

In accordance with your instruction vide your letter no.933 of September 13, 2016 I visited your Guwahati office where I met the manager, the salesman and all other concerned including many shop keepers who stock and sell our products and also some members of the public. The results of my finding is given below:

The sales of our soap has been quite satisfactory in the month of June till another soap company based in Guwahati appeared in the market. Since these soap are new and attractively packed, and since the new company wants to obtain a footing in the market, their prices is relatively very low. The result is that this new soap brands have caught the public eyes and are now being sold like hot cakes.

Another reason why the new soaps have begun replacing our brands is the intense publicity campaign started by the new company. our publicity on the contrary, is ineffective and is lagging far behind our standards. Moreover our

soaps are still packed in the same old design that begun seven years ago.

In view of these finding, I recomeneded that:

1. The quality of our soaps be improved, new brand of fragment quality must be developed. This soon be done as soon as possible. When these newly improved brands are sent to the market they should be priced at a relatively low . competitive level.
2. Immediate steps should be taken to organize a strong publicity and advertising campaign, the sooner it is done the better, otherwise the new company might easily capture the local market completely, our company would do well to acquire the services of a competent commercial artist to help us publish our product effectively.

In closing, I am pleased to report that all our employees at our Guwahati office are performing their duties most satisfactory. If any further clarification of some point Ifrequired, I may please be called at any time convient to you.

Yours truly
Mr. Jack

Conclusion



Being “willing to listen to feedback” from others and “follow their logical advice” is the logic behind in becoming a persuasive communicator and create reports that successfully convey the desired message.